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FASTEST GROWING
PACKAGED FOOD
COMPANY*

milkyMist®



Rs. 3,138 Cr
FY26 Revenue



31.26%
FY24 - FY26 CAGR



74,000+ Farmers[#]
Direct Sourcing of Raw Milk



640 SKUs
22 Product Categories[#]



3,75,000+[#]
Retail Touchpoints



4000+ Distributors
22 States & **5** UTs[#]

Exclusively focused on premium, value-added dairy products (Source: 1Lattice Report)

Diversified product categories

Manufacturing facilities equipped with advanced machinery to ensure consistent quality of products and operational efficiency

*(Among companies with revenue scale of more than ₹15,000 million) in India in terms of revenue, growing at a CAGR of 31.26% from Fiscal 2024 to Fiscal 2026. (Source: 1Lattice Report) | [#] As of March 31, 2026

MILKY MIST DAIRY FOOD LIMITED is proposing, subject to applicable statutory and regulatory requirements, receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offering of its Equity Shares and has filed the RHP with RoC, SEBI and the Stock Exchanges on August 4, 2026. The RHP shall be available on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in, and is available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE and NSE at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com, respectively, on the website of the Company at www.milkymist.com and the websites of the BRLMs, i.e., JM Financial Limited, Axis Capital Limited and IIFL Capital Services Limited (formerly known as IIFL Securities Limited) at www.jmfl.com, https://www.axiscapital.co.in/ and www.iiflcapital.com, respectively. Any potential investors should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and for details relating to such risk, see "Risk Factors" beginning on page 23 of the RHP. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP and should instead rely on their own examination of our Company and the Offer, including the risks involved, for making any investment decision. The Equity Shares offered in the Offer have not been and will not be registered under the U.S. Securities Act of 1933, as amended (the "U.S. Securities Act") or any state securities laws in the United States and, unless so registered, may not be offered or sold within the United States, except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and applicable state securities laws. Accordingly, such Equity Shares are being offered and sold (i) outside of the United States in offshore transactions in reliance on Regulation S under the U.S. Securities Act and the applicable laws of the jurisdiction where those offers and sales occur; and (ii) within the United States to "qualified institutional buyers" (as defined in Rule 144A under the U.S. Securities Act), pursuant to the private placement exemption set out in Section 4(a) of the U.S. Securities Act. The Equity Shares have not been and will not be registered, listed or otherwise qualified in any other jurisdiction outside India and may not be offered or sold, and Bids may not be made by persons in any such jurisdiction, except in compliance with the applicable laws of such jurisdiction. There will be no public offering in the United States.

milky mist[®]

MILKY MIST DAIRY FOOD LIMITED




**Largest Private
Packaged
Paneer
Brand***


**Largest Private
Packaged
Cheese
Brand****




**Among the
Top Two Largest
Private Packaged
Yogurt
Brands#**

*In the organized market with a market share of approximately 19% In terms of the organised packaged paneer market value in Fiscal 2026 in India (Source: 1Lattice Report) | **In South India in Fiscal 2026, with a market share of approximately 12% In terms of market value in the Southern region's organised cheese segment (Source: 1Lattice Report) | #With a market share of approximately 13% in terms of market value in the organized yogurt market in India (Source: 1Lattice Report)

MILKY MIST DAIRY FOOD LIMITED is proposing, subject to applicable statutory and regulatory requirements, receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offering of its Equity Shares and has filed the RHP with RoC, SEBI and the Stock Exchanges on August 4, 2026. The RHP shall be available on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in, and is available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE and NSE at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com, respectively, on the website of the Company at www.milkymist.com and the websites of the BRLMs, i.e., JM Financial Limited, Axis Capital Limited and IIFL Capital Services Limited (formerly known as IIFL Securities Limited) at www.jmfl.com, <https://www.axiscapital.co.in/> and www.iiflcapital.com, respectively. Any potential investors should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and for details relating to such risk, see "Risk Factors" beginning on page 23 of the RHP. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP and should instead rely on their own examination of our Company and the Offer, including the risks involved, for making any investment decision. The Equity Shares offered in the Offer have not been and will not be registered under the U.S. Securities Act of 1933, as amended (the "U.S. Securities Act") or any state securities laws in the United States and, unless so registered, may not be offered or sold within the United States, except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and applicable state securities laws. Accordingly, such Equity Shares are being offered and sold (i) outside of the United States in offshore transactions in reliance on Regulation S under the U.S. Securities Act and the applicable laws of the jurisdiction where those offers and sales occur; and (ii) within the United States to "qualified institutional buyers" (as defined in Rule 144A under the U.S. Securities Act), pursuant to the private placement exemption set out in Section 4(a) of the U.S. Securities Act. The Equity Shares have not been and will not be registered, listed or otherwise qualified in any other jurisdiction outside India and may not be offered or sold, and Bids may not be made by persons in any such jurisdiction, except in compliance with the applicable laws of such jurisdiction. There will be no public offering in the United States.

the hindu businessline

SENSEX 78499.17 (+404.53)

IN FOCUS



	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	24570.65	+187.05
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.87	+0.05
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.20	-0.18
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	149022.00	+6734
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	231381.00	+13086



LOGISTICS.

Thirty years after Gujarat shook hands with private players, its coastal economy faces a crucial test **p8**

PULSE.

Why cancer care largely continues to be funded out of pocket by insured patients **p9**

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MONDAY SPECIALS.

BRANDLINE

Daubing a fresh coat of inspiration



Doing up a room calls for way more than just picking the paint colour for the walls. Long before choosing a brand, homeowners think about how they would use the space: A distraction-free work den, a fun-themed child's bedroom or a cosy balcony? They look for inspiration and lifestyle ideas first. To meet these consumers early in their shopping journey, Indicus Paints creates themed content on Pinterest that is centred around spaces such as home-offices, staircases and balconies. **p6**

QUANTUM

Calls grow for India to test ANEEL fuel in its PHWRs

After US-based Clean Core Thorium Energy recently signed a fuel fabrication agreement with BWXT Canada to advance its thorium-based ANEEL nuclear fuel, calls are growing for India to become the first to test ANEEL in its pressurised heavy water reactors (PHWRs). **p7**

India unlikely to curb Russian oil purchase despite US threat

FIRM STANCE. Delhi signals little appetite to sacrifice energy, defence ties with Moscow

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India is unlikely to rein in crude oil purchases from Russia, its largest oil supplier, despite mounting pressure from Washington, with the US Senate overwhelmingly passing a sanctions Bill empowering President Donald Trump to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on imports from the top buyers of Russian oil and gas, sources said.

The legislation puts India, the second-largest buyer of Russian crude after China, directly in the line of fire. But New Delhi is expected to stay the course, not allowing its energy security and strategic ties with Russia to be dictated by external pressure, sources noted.

UNFAZED BY PRESSURE “India has long-enduring ties with Russia, and its defence and energy relationship is deeply entrenched. It cannot simply be given up under external pressure,” a person tracking the matter told *businessline*.

Despite tariff sanctions initiated in the US Senate, India imported a record 2.78



KEY PARTNER

- India imported a record 2.78 million barrels per day (mbd) of Russian crude in July
- Russian oil made up over 50% of India's total crude oil imports
- India's overall crude imports stood at 4.96 mbd during the month

million barrels per day (mbd) of Russian crude in July 2026, according to industry data. Against overall crude imports of 4.96 mbd by India during the month, Moscow accounted for more than half of its total oil buys.

“India's oil import data in July 2026 show that inflows from Russia touched a record high despite the US Senate advancing the sanctions Bill. This gives a fair idea about what the government has in mind and its unwillingness to curtail its ties with Moscow,” the source said. Moreover, the passing

of the sanctions Bill, officially the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026, would not immediately translate into action as it still has to clear the US House of Representatives. Also, the tariff would not be automatic.

“The legislation gives the President the authority to impose tariffs on top oil importers from Russia and does not automatically result in its imposition. There are already many voices in the US against the Bill, arguing that more duties on China and India would further raise

domestic prices. We need to wait and see what happens,” another source said.

New Delhi had moderated its oil purchases from Russia for a brief period last year after the Trump administration, on August 27, 2025, imposed 25 per cent duties on Indian imports.

IMPORT SURGE

However, crude imports from Moscow continued robustly through the year despite the tariffs, with shipments valued at \$40.82 billion accounting for about 30 per cent of the country's overall crude purchases in financial year 2025-26.

The US penal tariffs for Russian oil purchase were subsequently dropped on February 7, 2026, following the announcement of a framework interim trade deal by India and the US.

“India has a lot going with the US, including work on a bilateral trade pact. It has increased its energy imports from the US substantially. Imposing high tariffs on Indian goods is not a good idea for the American consumers as well. One must wait for the situation to develop without any knee-jerk reactions,” sources said.

AI may redraw India's IT services map; 20-25% of firms could struggle to cross over, says Nasscom chief

Sanjana B Venkatesha Babu
Bengaluru

India's technology services industry may be facing a painful transition but the underlying demand remains robust, with order books, future signings and deal pipelines continuing to strengthen, according to National Association of Software and Services Companies (Nasscom) President Rajesh Nambiar.

The bigger question, however, is whether all companies will be able to adapt to an AI-led business model. Nambiar estimates that 20-25 per cent of technology services

companies may not make the crossover from the traditional full time equivalent (FTE)-led model to one driven by AI, productivity and business outcomes.

“The industry will survive. The answer is yes, I think the industry can move. Will all the players in the industry make their transition? Maybe not,” Nambiar told *businessline*.

The industry's latest numbers underline the nature of the transition. Technology services revenue grew 6.1 per cent, while employee headcount rose just 2.3 per cent. The divergence is significant for an industry whose growth has historically been closely linked to hiring.



Rajesh Nambiar,
President, Nasscom

“That linearity has been broken,” Nambiar said, pointing to the trend over the past several quarters.

Yet, despite slower revenue growth, companies are seeing a “phenomenal amount of uptake” in order books. Future signings and deal pipelines have improved across the industry, even as

technology stocks faced heavy pressure from investors worried about the impact of AI and the returns on technology investments.

AI FOCUS

Nambiar believes the market may be focusing excessively on the near term. The fundamental driver of future demand, he said, is the need for enterprises to use AI not merely to improve productivity but to rethink and transform their businesses.

That shift will fundamentally alter the traditional technology services proposition. Billing customers for additional manpower will increasingly give way to outcome-based engagements,

where vendors are paid for the business value they create. The transition will inevitably create churn in the workforce and put pressure on companies whose businesses remain heavily dependent on staff augmentation. Mid-size and larger technology firms, Nambiar said, are better positioned because many have already begun building AI capabilities and changing their business models.

For the industry, therefore, the question is no longer whether AI will disrupt the services model. It is which companies will successfully cross the chasm and which will be left behind.

Interview p3

Loss-making MF schemes nearly triple in FY26

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The mutual fund industry continued to grow in asset and investor numbers in FY26, but the number of schemes posting negative

annual returns nearly tripled to 731 from 243 a year ago.

Schemes delivering returns of more than 10 per cent fell to 198 from 304. The shift was broad-based, with the number of schemes with returns between zero and

minus 5 per cent jumping to 492 in FY26 from 172 a year ago. Schemes with returns between minus 5 per cent and minus 10 per cent increased to 146 from 41, per SEBI's latest annual report.

Details p2

IAM Ignite Museum unfolds a new chapter in tech history

Put together by ex-TCS veterans, it will showcase the Information Age revolutions

KV Kurmanath
Hyderabad

Hyderabad is stepping into the future with India's first phygital Information Age Museum. Mapping 70 years of the country's tech history, the mobile museum being set up at the city's Indian Institute of Technology will take visitors through the birth and rise of the IT industry and the digital and AI revolutions.

This will be the first of a chain of information age museums being put together by a group of ex-TCS veterans, including S Ramadorai and S Mahalingam, with the goal of showcasing the country's tech achievements. The veterans set up the Forum of Erstwhile TCS Leaders and IT Advisors (FORTESS) a few years ago to roll out the project.

The maiden IAM Ignite at IIT-Hyderabad has an outlay of ₹4 crore. The 2,200 sq



PHYGITAL REVOLUTION. An artistic representation of Information Age Museum Ignite, which is being established by FORTESS at IIT-Hyderabad

ft museum, housed in three containers, is slated for launch by the year-end.

SEVERAL FEATURES

It will have 11 installations, display objects and an immersion zone, engaging about 25 visitors at any time. Students from 60-70 schools will be invited to see the artefacts and interact with technology.

“Throughout India's IT journey, there have been many unique hurdles and innovations, and these stories need to be explained us-

ing physical artifacts. The museum aims to showcase this evolution in a way that helps people truly understand the impact of technology and to illustrate how the foundations for a modern computing mindset were developed over time,” S Mahalingam, former CFO of TCS, told *businessline*.

Each of these major centres will require a minimum of ₹250 crore, excluding land costs, as they must be built in accessible locations, he said. “We plan to raise these funds through a

combination of local and global corporate champions who operate in India, as well as institutional beneficiaries like banks, who are eager to tell the story of how technology transformed their operations,” he added.

THREE FORMATS

The plans are ambitious with three distinct formats. While IAM Ignite will feature museums housed in custom-built containers that can be moved easily, a bigger format will be Discovery Centres planned for metros such as Delhi, Kolkata, Chennai and Hyderabad. And then, there will be a central museum spanning over 50,000 sq ft.

Rather than overwhelming visitors with a library of information, the museum's curation follows a “less is more” philosophy, distilling a billion pages of industry history into core, experiential nuggets, according to Birad Yagnik, the curator

designing the IAM Ignite museums. “The focus will be on tactile and experiential learning. Visitors will interact with past technology, such as fax machines, floppy disks and punch cards, including the type that originally ran the Golconda Fort sound-and-light show in Amitabh Bachchan's voice,” he said.

“IAM has the potential to become the largest connected museum ecosystem in the world, not measured by the size of one building, but by the number of institutions it connects and the millions of minds it inspires,” PVLN Rao, Incubator and Advisor of IAM, told *businessline* from New Jersey.

“It will build a vibrant ecosystem, connecting students, researchers, innovators, industry and entrepreneurs,” PR Krishnan, former Executive V-P of TCS and Honorary Secretary of FORTESS, said.

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QUICKLY.

Suvendu orders fresh probe into RG Kar case

Kolkata: West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Sunday announced a fresh probe into the 2024 rape and murder of a doctor at the State-run RG Kar Medical College and Hospital. Adhikari said that the government took the decision on the request of the deceased doctor's mother, who is now a BJP MLA. "Ratna Debnath had written to me, requesting a fresh investigation. After extensive discussions with the Chief Secretary and experts, I am announcing a fresh investigation under the Special Commission Act, 1952," he said.

Nabard handloom fair clocks ₹67 lakh in sales

Mumbai: Nabard's three-day National Handloom Day exhibition-cum-sale in Mumbai recorded sales of more than ₹67 lakh as the demand for traditional handloom products continues to grow. The event, held from August 5 to 7, showcased 15 weaving traditions from 14 States, including nine GI-registered (Geographical Indication registration) products. The traditions showcased included Paithani, Pochampally Ikat, Kota Doriya, Sambalpuri, Bhagalpur silk, Kantha stitch and Kutch shawls.

Loss-making mutual fund schemes nearly triple in FY26

DRYING UP. 731 schemes post negative annual returns against 243 in the previous year

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The mutual fund industry continued to grow in asset and investor numbers in FY26, but the number of schemes posting negative annual returns nearly tripled to 731 from 243 a year earlier.

Meanwhile, schemes delivering returns of more than 10 per cent fell to 198 from 304.

The shift was broad-based, with the number of schemes with returns between zero and minus 5 per cent jumping to 492 in FY26 from 172 a year ago.

Schemes with returns between minus 5 per cent and minus 10 per cent increased to 146 from 41, while those with returns of minus 10 per cent or worse rose to 93 from 30.

At the other end of the return spectrum, the number of schemes delivering more than 10 per cent returns fell to 198 from 304.

Schemes generating more than 5 per cent returns declined to 737 from 1,156, while those delivering between 5 per cent and 10



HIGH INTEREST. Tier-2 cities recorded a 37.6% increase in investors to 1.4 crore from 1 crore, while tier-3 cities had the largest investor base at 3.4 crore, up from 3.3 crore

per cent fell to 539 from 852.

The number of schemes delivering between zero and 5 per cent returns, however, rose to 373 from 218, according to the Securities and Exchange Board of India's (SEBI) latest annual report.

WEAKER RETURNS

The data show a shift in the distribution of annual scheme returns, with the largest increase coming in schemes that ended the year with relatively small losses.

SEBI said that the change is due to a more subdued return environment and market volatility.

The weaker return distribution came even as the mutual fund industry expanded in assets and investor parti-

cipation. Total assets under management rose 12.2 per cent to ₹73.7 lakh crore at the end of March 2026 from ₹65.7 lakh crore a year earlier. Equity-oriented schemes recorded net inflows of ₹3.5 lakh crore during FY26, led by flexi-cap funds at ₹89,213 crore, small-cap funds at ₹51,872 crore and mid-cap funds at ₹51,197 crore.

NET INFLOWS

Overall mutual-fund net inflows, however, declined 9.7 per cent to ₹7.4 lakh crore from ₹8.2 lakh crore in FY25 as a 16.5 per cent increase in redemptions offset a 14.9 per cent rise in gross mobilisation to ₹157.5 lakh crore.

Eight new mutual fund as-

Scheme-wise annual return	2024-25	2025-26
Per cent		
<= -10	30	93
from -10 to <= -5	41	146
from -5 to <=0	172	492
from 0 to <=5	218	373
from 5 to <=10	852	539
> 10	304	198

Note: Annual returns for Direct Plan Growth Option of schemes
Source: SEBI

set management companies (AMCs) came into the industry during the year. The number of unique mutual fund investors increased 13.2 per cent to 6.1 crore from 5.4 crore.

CONTRIBUTIONS RISE

Tier-2 cities recorded a 37.6 per cent increase in investors to 1.4 crore from 1 crore, while tier-3 cities remained the largest investor base at 3.4 crore, up from 3.3 crore.

SIP participation also increased, with contributing SIP accounts rising to 10.45 crore from 10.05 crore.

Average monthly net SIP contributions rose 25.8 per cent to ₹16,413 crore from ₹13,052 crore.

Govt considering cap on Carbosulfan insecticide after plans to ban Paraquat

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

The government is considering restricting the use of Carbosulfan, a popular insecticide used on paddy, cotton and horticulture crops, with a final decision expected by the end of this month.

Coming on the heels of July's proposed ban on herbicide Paraquat, the move reflects growing official efforts to improve food safety and promote healthier agricultural practices.

Currently, FMC India, under its 'Marshal' brand, sells the insecticide, which contains 25 per cent (emulsifiable concentrate) Carbosulfan.

"Marshal insecticide, a trusted brand among farmers for decades, is known for its broad spectrum control on various chewing and sucking pests in cotton, paddy and vegetables. A different mode of action makes Marshal insecticide a good rotational partner, especially in vegetable spray programmes and manages issues around pest resistance," according to the FMC India website.

FMC Corporation in May signed a definitive agreement to sell its India commercial business to Crystal Crop Protection for \$252 million, under which Crystal will acquire FMC India's



commercial operations in the crop protection segment, including licences for the FMC brands sold in India.

Crystal will also receive a preferred supply agreement for certain FMC active ingredients and formulated products, along with preferred access to FMC's pipeline of crop protection products in India.

Sources said that the Agriculture Ministry, which has categorised Carbosulfan under "highly toxic", started acting on the proposal to put it under the restricted category only after it received the recommendation of the Central Insecticides Board and Registration Committee (CIB&RC). The RC, in its meeting held on June 29, perused the report of the expert review committee on Paraquat Dichloride and Carbosulfan, and deliberated it extensively under Section 27(2) of the Insecticides Act, 1968.

"RC decided to communicate its recommendations separately to the Government of India for its consid-

eration and taking a final appropriate view in the matter. The final decision taken by the Government of India shall be implemented by the RC accordingly," according to the minutes of the meeting.

PARAQUAT BAN

The government had on July 14 issued a draft order proposing a blanket ban on Paraquat Dichloride, citing its severe toxicity to humans and animals.

The draft notification seeks to halt the manufacture, import, sale and distribution of the widely used herbicide, giving stakeholders 30 days (by August 12) to submit feedback before a final ban is gazetted.

Industry sources said that once Carbosulfan is put under the restrictive category, there can be various types of restrictions to regulate its use by farmers, who currently freely use it.

Industry sources also said that unlike 'Paraquat', there is not much concern about Carbosulfan with regard to toxicity or other health risks.

However, sources said that the issue was referred to the expert panel by the RC as Carbosulfan had been added to the Rotterdam Convention, under which all signatories (countries) when importing the formulation have to notify it.

'Car sales to hit 6.3 million units by FY31, small cars to grow faster'

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Fuelled by GST reforms, the car industry will grow to 6.1-6.3 million by financial year 2030-31 and the share of the small car market will grow significantly faster than what happened in the last five years, RC Bhargava, Chairman, Maruti Suzuki India (MSIL), has said.

"National GDP growth figures since the GST reforms have been better than were forecast by most agencies," he said. "Despite the Iran-US war that adversely affected most global economies, the Indian economy continues to do well and remains the fastest growing among larger countries," Bhargava noted.

"GST collections, despite rates of tax being reduced on over 90 per cent of products, have shown buoyancy and

reached new high levels. I believe that without GST reforms we may not have done so well in the difficult months that have elapsed... I am happy to inform you that these GST reforms have given a new impetus not only to the automobile industry but to several sectors of the economy," Bhargava said.

RECORD SALES

FY2025-26 was a record year for MSIL that achieved the highest level of sales of 24.22 lakh vehicles, highest exports of 4.47 lakh cars, highest production of 23.4 lakh cars and highest consolidated revenues of ₹1.83 lakh crore, he said, adding that the annual profit at ₹14,445.4 crore was the highest ever.

"Overall, after the implementation of the new GST rates on September 22, 2025, MSIL retail sales grew 17 per cent in the second half of last



RC Bhargava, Chairman, Maruti Suzuki India

year. We ended March with 1.9 lakh pending bookings, a result of inadequate manufacturing capacity of the models in demand. This was the consequence of adjustments made over the past several years to cater to the fall in small car sales and the growth of the SUV market," the Maruti Chairman noted.

He said MSIL was remedying this situation by making all its new production lines flexible enough to change platforms and models as may be required. This is already

showing results and in the first quarter of this year, MSIL's sales grew by 38 per cent, while industry grew 28 per cent. The sales of small cars grew 17 per cent in the second half of last year but grew 35 per cent in first quarter this year.

"Our economy has huge potential for growth. The government is committed to taking the economy along a sustained high growth path. The automotive industry will follow as the ability to commute comfortably and safely is a constituent of a developed economy... We have to take into account not only the implications of artificial intelligence but also, as good citizens, to ensure that we play our part in meeting all the requirements of environmental protection and safety," he said.

On India's journey towards Net Zero, Bhargava strongly believed that biogas

could be generated in large quantities from locally available resources.

MSIL'S CNG PLANS

"The Maruti Suzuki Board has approved that we start four biogas plants in the first phase, at a cost of ₹561 crore, and once we have learnt more about the process and technology, we hope to invest substantial amounts of money in production and distribution," the Maruti Chairman said.

It will provide zero emission fuel and reduce the pressure on CNG and on burning coal for generating electricity, he said.

"The sales of cars in rural areas are growing faster than in urban areas, and we are accordingly implementing the expansion of sales, service and spare part outlets."

Bhargava urged the government to proceed faster on the road of reforms and in-

crease efforts to make doing business easier.

"Use more technology as it has shown that it reduces corruption and delays. Time saving is a major factor in lowering costs of production. Trust the private sector and the power of competition. Faster creation of wealth, in the most efficient manner, is the only way that India can make up for the time that we have lost. This has been demonstrated by the automobile sector," he noted, adding that large employment opportunities had opened up due to a competitive industry.

"My request to all political parties is to support reforms and programmes that create wealth. The government and the Opposition should ensure that the additional resources that would be generated would be used to create a more equitable and just society," Bhargava added.

IN-SPACE invites private operators for management of TN space complex

Our Bureau
Chennai

The Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (IN-SPACE) has come out with an expression of interest (EOI) for the handover of responsibility of operation and management of the soon-to-be-launched SSV Launch Complex (SLC) in Kulasekarapattinam, near Thoothukudi in Tamil Nadu.

The launch complex, expected to be commissioned by the end of this year, will be the Indian Space Research Organisation's second space port after the

Satish Dhawan Space Centre in Sriharikota.

The EOI intends to invite responses from Indian industries with demonstrated experience in executing and managing largescale, multidisciplinary infrastructure and operations projects.

OPERATOR ELIGIBILITY

The eligibility criteria for the operator includes companies that have been operational for at least seven years as well as an annual turnover of above ₹2,000 crore for any three years of the last five years.

It also requires the companies to have a minimum net worth of ₹1,000 crore.

"To facilitate a smooth transition and capability development, ISRO will provide the selected party with the necessary technical guidance, operational support, training and handholding assistance until the completion of three launch services provided by the selected party to launch vehicle operators or one year, whichever is earlier," the EOI added.

The new spaceport will bolster India's private launch capabilities at a time when start-ups such as Skyroot Aerospace and Agnikul Cosmos are in the process of building private launch vehicles.

Britannia's overseas recovery remains uneven as supply chain pressures ease

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Britannia Industries' international business began recovering sequentially in the June quarter as supply chain disruptions eased towards the end of the period, although performance remained uneven across markets, with Africa, particularly Kenya, emerging as a bright spot while the Middle East and North America continued to face challenges.

The company's international operations had come under pressure from disruptions linked to the West Asia

conflict, which also drove up fuel and shipment costs across its domestic and overseas businesses. Chief Executive Officer and Managing Director Rakshit Hargave said the company was closely monitoring the evolving geopolitical situation.

SUPPLY CHALLENGE

Despite the external pressures, Britannia reported a 14 per cent year-on-year increase in consolidated net profit to ₹593 crore in the first quarter of FY27, while revenue from operations rose 9.5 per cent to ₹4,964 crore. Operating profit grew 12.7 per cent during the

quarter. Hargave said supply-chain constraints in the international business began normalising towards the latter part of the quarter, helping the business recover sequentially. While Africa, led by Kenya, performed well, the Middle East, including Saudi Arabia, and North America remained challenging markets.

Hargave said the West Asia conflict had resulted in a steep increase in fuel and shipment charges. Palm oil prices increased more than 20 per cent from the February levels, while sugar, milk and industrial fuel remained cost pressure areas.

Tomato, onion, potato prices push up July vegetarian thali cost

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Rising prices of tomato, onion and potato pushed up the cost of a home-cooked vegetarian thali in July, signalling renewed pressure on household food budgets during the monsoon season.

However, a sharp decline in vegetable prices and lower broiler chicken rates compared with last year helped keep both vegetarian and non-vegetarian thalis significantly cheaper on an annual basis, according to Crisil's latest Roti Rice Rate report.

The average cost of a vegetarian thali rose 4 per cent month-on-month to ₹28.1 in July from ₹27.1 in June. The index measures the average cost of preparing a thali at

Premium on plate		m-o-m (% change)
Month	Non-veg thali	Veg thali
Aug 2025	2	4
Sep 2025	3	-3
Oct 2025	-3	-1
Nov 2025	-1	2
Dec 2025	8	2
Jan 2026	-3	-2
Feb 2026	-1	-5
Mar 2026	-2	-1
Apr 2026	1	0
May 2026	3	3
Jun 2026	3	4
Jul 2026	0	2

The index measures the average cost of preparing a thali at home based on input prices prevailing across North, South, East and West India. Source: Crisil

home based on input prices prevailing across North, South, East and West India.

In contrast, the cost of a non-vegetarian thali fell 2 per cent to ₹53.5 from ₹54.8 in the previous month.

On a year-on-year basis, however, the picture was markedly different. The vegetarian thali cost was 14 per cent lower than in July last year, while the non-vegetarian thali was around 13 per cent cheaper, reflecting a broad-based moderation in food prices from the elevated levels seen a year ago.

KEY STAPLES

The primary driver of the month-on-month increase in the vegetarian thali was tomato.

Prices of the kitchen staple surged 31 per cent in July after market arrivals declined 27 per cent, highlighting seasonal supply con-

straints that often emerge during the monsoon. Adding to the pressure, potato prices increased 2 per cent while onion prices rose 5 per cent, making everyday meals costlier for households.

Despite the recent rise, prices of key vegetables remained substantially below year-ago levels. Tomato prices fell 36 per cent year-on-year to ₹42 per kg, compared with ₹66 per kg in July last year.

Potato and onion prices declined 30 per cent and 36 per cent respectively, aided by improved production and a favourable base effect.

Last year, potato prices had risen sharply because of crop losses caused by blight infestation and adverse weather, while higher onion production this year boosted

supplies and eased prices.

Other food ingredients also contributed to lower annual thali costs. Pulses prices dropped 14 per cent year-on-year due to better output and comfortable stock levels, while rice prices fell 4 per cent, offering some relief to consumers.

MAJOR RELIEF

Not all items became cheaper, though. Vegetable oil prices rose 20 per cent year-on-year, while LPG cylinder prices increased 6 per cent, preventing a steeper decline in thali costs despite softer vegetable prices.

For non-vegetarian consumers, lower broiler prices proved a major relief.

Broiler chicken, which accounts for nearly half the cost of a non-vegetarian

thali, declined an estimated 12 per cent year-on-year and 9 per cent month-on-month.

The fall was attributed to weaker demand during the monsoon and the Shravan period, when many consumers traditionally avoid meat consumption.

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Upward momentum

Tractor OEM	July 2025 sales (units)	Market share (%)	July 2026 sales (units)	Market share (%)
M & M (Tractor)	20,617	23	26,863	23
M & M (Swaraj Division)	16,733	18	22,334	19
International Tractors	12,824	14	15,991	14
TAFE Ltd	9,655	11	14,178	12
Escorts Kubota (FADA Machinery Group)	9,202	10	12,782	11

Source: FADA Research

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

India's tractor market recorded strong growth in July 2026, with retail sales rising 28 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) to 1,17,349 units, compared with 91,604 units in July 2025, according to data from the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA), the apex national body of the automobile retail industry.

The July volume was a record for the month, with rural tractor demand benefiting from the catch-up in kharif sowing and the improving monsoon conditions, FADA said.

TOP PERFORMERS

All tractor manufacturers reported growth in July. Mahindra & Mahindra (Tractor) remained the market leader, followed by its Swaraj division ranked second and International Tractors Ltd third. Chennai-based TAFE, which reported the highest growth in July, and Escorts Kubota rounded off the top five.

Veejay Nakra, President - Farm Equipment Business, Mahindra & Mahindra Ltd, in the company's monthly

business update on tractors, said that significant recovery in rainfall, improved reservoir levels and accelerated kharif sowing aided by government support had led to positive rural and farmer sentiment.

Escorts Kubota Ltd (Agri Machinery Business) said improved rainfall during the month of July reduced cumulative rainfall deficit to 14-15 per cent and kharif sowing activity picked up pace, thereby supporting rural demand and sentiments.

Retail tractor volumes grew 28 per cent y-o-y and 12 per cent over June, taking the four-month FY27 tally to 25 per cent, among the strongest starts the segment has seen in recent years.

Part of this reflects a favourable base since July last year had actually seen a decline, flattering the comparison somewhat. Monsoon progress had helped too, said Poonam Upadhyay, Director, Crisil Ratings.

After a slow start in June, rainfall picked up, and July saw fairly adequate distribution, barring a few pockets, allowing kharif sowing to catch up and keep farmer sentiment and dealership footfalls healthy, she said.

LAMBODHARA TEXTILES LIMITED					
CIN L17111 TZ 1994 PLC 004929					
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Email & Investor Grievance ID : info@lambodharatextiles.com Web: www.lambodharatextiles.com					
EXTRACT OF UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30.06.2026 (Rs. in Lakhs)					
S. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended		Year Ended	
		30.06.2026	31.03.2026	30.06.2025	31.03.2026
		Unaudited	Audited	Unaudited	Audited
1	Total Income from Operations	5,584.98	5,829.41	6,110.43	24,320.04
2	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary Items)	520.30	219.72	301.33	1,179.72
3	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary Items)	520.30	219.72	301.33	1,179.72
4	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and / or Extraordinary Items)	357.10	312.92	215.53	1,100.48
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period (Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after tax) and other Comprehensive Income (after tax)	347.11	353.58	215.66	1,142.30
6	Equity Share Capital	518.88	518.88	518.88	518.88
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance sheet of the Previous Year	-	-	-	11,536.65
8	Earnings per equity share Basic Diluted	3.44 3.44	3.02 3.02	2.08 2.08	10.60 10.60
Notes:					
1 The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly Unaudited Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly Unaudited Financial Results are available on the website of the Stock Exchange(s) (URL: www.sebiindia.com and www.bsindia.com) and on the Company's website (URL: www.lambodharatextiles.com). The results can be accessed by scanning the QR code provided below.					
2 The above financial results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee at their Meeting on 08th August 2026 and approved by the Board of Directors at their meeting held on 08th August 2026.					
3 The results have been prepared in accordance with the Companies (Indian Accounting Standards) Rules, 2015 (Ind AS) prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 and other recognised accounting practices and policies to the extent applicable.					
4 Consolidated Financial Statements are not applicable to the company as the company has no Subsidiaries/ Associates/Joint Ventures.					
Place : Coimbatore Date : 8th August 2026				By Order of the Board sd/- Giulia Bosco DIN : 01898020 Whole-Time Director	

‘Outcome-based IT services no longer optional’

bl.interview

Venkatesha Babu
Sanjana B
Bengaluru

India’s \$315 billion IT industry is navigating one of its biggest transitions as AI reshapes business models, hiring patterns and client expectations.

Rajesh Nambiar, President of IT industry body Nasscom, discusses how AI is changing the economics of IT services, why outcome-based delivery is becoming inevitable, the industry’s AI readiness, talent and policy priorities.

Edited excerpts:

You said AI has become the operating system for every enterprise. From your industry-wide vantage point today, where do you think India’s nearly \$300 billion IT services industry stands in its AI transformation journey?

Over the last 1.5 years, this industry has not been the most sought-after from a market perspective. While we grew 6.1 per cent, employee growth has been slow at 2.3 per cent growth. Historically, revenue growth in the industry has largely moved in tandem with employee growth. This linearity has been broken, especially in the last four quarters, where headcount growth has been less.

We find two things to be true. One is a phenomenal uptake in terms of the order books. Revenue growth is not bad; some large companies will register 2-3 per cent growth, which is still significant.

The industry will clock around 6-7 per cent growth because of some mid-sized companies.

In terms of order books, the future signings are positive and have gone up for every player. The deal

pipeline is good.

What’s not good is the market’s reaction to the results. Both Indian and global services companies are being punished; most had significant headwinds from a stock market point of view.

But if you look underneath the surface, you will find that things are not that bad. There will be a temporary churn in the system: how employment is restructured, changes in job descriptions. However, two years down the line, the industry will return with more growth than earlier.

This optimism comes from the rapid growth of technology and its infusion into enterprises. To change how enterprises work, a lot of help is required from the services industry, which understands enterprises best.

The traditional FTE-based services model appears to be under pressure, while AI-driven productivity gains are increasingly benefiting customers more than service providers. Do you see these trends accelerating, and can India’s IT services industry successfully adapt?

The industry has been wanting to transition from the headcount used for time and materials (T&M) to a fixed-price or outcome-based model. Very few could move the needle away from the FTE or T&M-based model. Today, there is no choice. The external environment, along with AI, is forcing us to make that change. The industry can’t rely purely on the number of hours billed.

While the industry will survive this shift, not all players may transition. 20-25 per cent of the companies may be left behind, including those whose DNA includes the FTE model.

Most mid-size or larger organisations have already begun the transition. Many are announcing AI-based

AI is not only about making the current processes or software development more productive, but also about helping clients reimagine value chains

RAJESH NAMBIAR
President, Nasscom



revenue and AI services, which may be only 10 per cent of their revenue currently, but will gradually bulge.

Some firms are working deeply with customer organisations. AI is not only about making current processes or software development more productive, but also about helping clients reimagine their value chains and how they make money. To do this, companies need to build the required capabilities and wherewithal, which is happening as we speak. They will increasingly be able to offer customers a much more outcome-driven business model, instead of the input-driven conversations of the past. This shift is already underway.

Drawing on both your policy and industry experience, do you think India’s IT services sector has been too complacent in investing in AI, compute and foundational capabilities? Barring a few notable bets, has the industry underinvested?

I would not say we are complacent. At the commercial end of running a services company, you do what shareholders value. One needs to both balance short-term results and create long-term capability.

Many technology firms have an R&D ecosystem. They’ve attempted to pivot into products. But as a nation, India spends roughly

0.65 per cent of its GDP on R&D, while most advanced nations spend upwards of 2.8 per cent.

Many Indian tech firms have invested in Silicon Valley start-ups at the forefront of technology. However, large- and mid-sized services firms are conservative by nature. This doesn’t mean they couldn’t have spent more on R&D, but when you have a shareholder to answer to, you are hesitant to spend on other things.

Patient capital is a new phenomenon in DeepTech, where the returns will take longer. To some extent, the two are comparable. These tech firms are cash-rich. Instead of explaining that some investments have a long gestation, they probably catered more to the investors.

GCCs were once seen as complementary to IT services firms, but are increasingly viewed as competitors. Will GCCs eventually overtake the traditional IT services industry in scale and employment or will the two continue to coexist with distinct roles?

Almost every services company has created a GCC practice to serve the GCC ecosystem. Initially, they were pushing back, but over the last five years, they have learned that this is also a revenue stream.

The GCC practices embedded within service providers are also growing. While the two may look sim-

ilar, the opportunities they offer are different. Service providers expose employees to multiple industries over a short period, providing broader domain experience that GCCs may not. GCCs, on the other hand, often offer greater responsibility and deeper expertise within a single domain.

Over the last couple of quarters, the net addition of employees is probably higher in GCCs. But both have to grow. It will boil down to the individual companies. That’s where the competition would be.

With over half of the industry’s revenue coming from a single geography (the US), how concerned are you about rising geopolitical and policy uncertainty? How can Nasscom help the industry navigate these risks and strengthen global engagement?

The 63 per cent of our revenues depend on one geography, which we believe puts pressure on the industry. The good news is that it has not directly impacted revenues because there is a lot of talk and little implementation. The problem is that because we deal with services, there is no direct tariff. Instead, a tariff may apply to a customer, who may pay a levy on services.

The bigger problem would be around skilled talent mobility. There have been some aberrations in terms of some fees. While companies have learned to live with it, it has caused some discomfort and ease of doing business has been taken away. We hope that once we sign a bilateral trade agreement, we will eventually get out of this.

Our government is supportive and we work closely with the Department of Commerce and the rest of the government in terms of external affairs as well. We also started a Nasscom US-CEO forum 1.5 years ago.

bl Changemaker Awards jury to meet today

Our Bureau
Chennai



Presents



Powered by



The *businessline* Changemaker Awards 2026 jury will meet on Monday to evaluate shortlisted nominees in social, digital and financial transformation.

The eighth Changemaker Awards will celebrate impactful people and organisations on September 22 in New Delhi. SASTRA Deemed University is the presenting partner, powered by City Union Bank.

The award selection jury will meet in Chennai on Monday. Chaired by Justice (retired) Prabha Sridevan, the 2026 jury includes Suresh Narayanan, Safeena Hussain, B Santhanam, NS Nappinai, A Balasubramanian and Dr Mukund Rajan.

Seven editions of the awards have been held since 2018, the year *The Hindu businessline* stepped into its 25th year of publishing. The 2021 edition could not be held due to the pandemic.

The awards are given across six categories — Changemaker: Financial Transformation; Changemaker: Digital Transformation; Changemaker: Social Transformation; Young Changemaker; Changemaker of the Year and Iconic Changemaker.

NOMINATIONS

Over 1,600 nominations across five categories were received for the awards, starting with a public call on May 12. Simultaneously,

businessline journalists and knowledge partners — Ashoka Foundation and Deloitte — nominated potential candidates. The submission window closed at midnight on July 7, and all entries underwent multiple screening rounds based on the selection criteria.

The awards feature five categories: Social, Digital, and Financial Transformation, alongside Young Changemaker and Iconic Changemaker. The flagship Changemaker of the Year award honours far-reaching impact.

The *businessline* editorial team and knowledge partners select the Iconic Changemaker nominees.

THE PROCESS

After the nomination window closes, *businessline* and knowledge partners Deloitte

and Ashoka screen and evaluate the applications.

Niiti Consulting, the validation partner, then validates the shortlisted nominees before an independent jury selects the winners.

2025 WINNERS

In 2025, DRDO won Changemaker of the Year, while the Azim Premji Foundation was named Iconic Changemaker. Araku Valley Coffee received the Financial Transformation award and Bhashini won for Digital Transformation. Impulse NGO Network took home the Social Transformation honour.

The Young Changemaker award was shared by Kalyani Shinde and the Young Tinker Foundation.

The awards for 2025 were given away by Hardeep Singh Puri, Union Minister of Petroleum and Natural Gas.

TODAY’S PICK.

Physicswallah (₹131.50): **BUY**

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

The trend has been up for the stock of Physicswallah since March. While it recently witnessed a correction in price, the chart shows the formation of a new base at ₹123, where

the 50-day moving average coincides. We expect the scrip to witness a fresh leg of rally on the back of this. In the near-term, the stock has the potential to rally to ₹155.

A breakout of this could lift it to ₹170. Since the outlook is bullish, traders can go long on the stock now at ₹131.50 and

buy more shares if the price dips to ₹125. Place the initial stop-loss at ₹117.

When the stock rises to ₹145, raise the stop-loss to ₹138.

Tighten the stop-loss to ₹145 when the price hits ₹150. Book profits at ₹155.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

No immunity, no data: Legal gap clouds GIFT City’s data embassy aspirations

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Countries such as the UAE and Singapore have expressed interest in establishing data embassies in India. However, the government’s ambition to position GIFT City as a hub for foreign government data repositories faces a key legal challenge — the absence of a framework that provides protection to sovereign data comparable to diplomatic immunity.

Legal experts with operations in GIFT City, including Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas and Khaitan & Co, said India lacks a dedicated legal framework defining the status of data embassies and providing enforceable safeguards for the data, systems and premises hosted in the country.

“Several countries, including Singapore and the UAE, have shown interest in setting up data embassies in India. However, the single biggest hurdle remains the



absence of a dedicated legal framework that grants data embassies formal recognition and provides the premises and data stored within them inviolability and immunity from Indian laws governing search, seizure, interception, requisition or other forms of access by domestic authorities,” Ketaki Mehta, Partner, GIFT City, at Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas, told *businessline*.

DATA EMBASSIES

The government first announced plans to facilitate data embassies in GIFT IFSC in the Union Budget 2023.

The Interim Budget for 2024 further stated that such facilities would primarily be enabled through bilateral agreements.

The International Financial Services Centres Authority has since submitted a framework and concept note, including a draft MoU, which remains under examination by the Central government, according to legal experts.

Supratim Chakraborty, Partner at Khaitan & Co, said the challenge for India lies in legal certainty. “In response to changing geopolitical and regulatory realities, the global conversation has shifted away from the assumption of frictionless cross-border data flows towards trusted data flows. Under this, countries increasingly expect robust privacy protections, national security safeguards, regulatory certainty and predictable government-access rules before permitting critical governmental data to be hosted abroad. In this environment,

data embassies may become even more relevant,” said Chakraborty.

FUNCTIONAL IMMUNITY Experts said data embassies may not require full diplomatic immunity under the Vienna Convention on diplomatic relations.

However, they would require functional immunity for the premises, information systems, equipment, communications, archives and sovereign data stored within them.

Khaitan & Co said India could establish a digital inviolability framework. “Under this, India will retain territorial sovereignty and continue to regulate matters like physical infrastructure, utilities and public safety. However, the sovereign data and information systems housed within the data embassy will remain under the exclusive legal control and jurisdiction of the home state, subject only to mutually agreed access mechanisms,” Chakraborty added.

India, emerging markets power pharma majors

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

Domestic branded formulations, innovative medicines and emerging markets are increasingly cushioning major Indian drugmakers against volatility and pricing pressure in US generics.

businessline.

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An analysis of the first quarter numbers (FY27) of Sun Pharma, Aurobindo Pharma and Dr Reddy’s Laboratories shows that business in India and emerging markets powered the sector’s growth amid a general slowdown in the US market.

The Q1 performance of these drugmakers shows divergence as Sun Pharma and Aurobindo Pharma posted strong revenue growth, while Dr Reddy’s Laboratories suffered a sharp earnings decline on account of lower lenalidomide sales and a semaglutide-related provision.

SUN PHARMA SHINES Sun Pharma remained the

largest of the three, with Q1FY27 sales rising 10 per cent year-on-year to ₹15,184 crore. EBITDA increased at a slower 2.7 per cent to ₹4,418 crore, while the margin contracted to 28.9 per cent from 31.1 per cent.

Reported net profit rose to ₹2,895 crore from ₹2,279 crore, though adjusted profit grew only 3.1 per cent to ₹3,089 crore.

Sun’s growth was driven by India formulations, which expanded 16 per cent to ₹5,475 crore. Sales rose 12.8 per cent to \$351 million at Global Innovative Medicines.

Innovative medicines contributed 21.9 per cent of total sales, underscoring

the company’s continuing shift towards higher-value products.

Aurobindo saw the fastest overall growth with a 16.3 per cent increase in total revenue at ₹9,150 crore, while EBITDA increased 20 per cent to ₹1,924 crore.

Its EBITDA margin improved by 60 basis points to 21 per cent, and net profit surged 25 per cent to ₹1,032 crore.

Dr Reddy’s reported a contrasting performance as revenue fell 5.6 per cent to ₹8,071 crore, EBITDA dropped to ₹1,009 crore from ₹2,278 crore, and profit attributable to shareholders declined 69 per cent to ₹444 crore.

ॐ

OM NAMAH SHIVAYA!

“இன்பமும் துன்பமும் இல்லாதான் தான் சேர்ந்தார்”

Inbamum thunbamum illaadhaan thaal serndhaar

“Those who reach His feet are beyond joy and sorrow”

23.02.1950 - 26.07.2026

Daughter of Dr. N Mahalingam
Wife of Dr. B K Krishnaraj Vanavarayar

A source of strength to her family, she touched countless lives with her warmth, wisdom, and unwavering values. A simple guiding force in fostering our spiritual and cultural heritage, she dedicated her life to nurturing faith, inspiring generations, and serving society with selfless devotion. A life of grace, humility and dedication, her examples live in us.

We sincerely express our profound grief and whole heartedly pray God to Rest Her Soul in peace and give her vast family members the strength to bear the loss of her untimely death.

We deeply mourn her death:
The Management and Staff Members of
Sri Chamundeswari Sugars Limited

Chamundeswari
LIFE IN HARMONY

Strategic reforms

Focus on small ticket disinvestment is paying off

In recent years, the Centre has chosen to adopt a different tack on disinvestment — one that is predicated on unobtrusive minority stake sales in central public sector undertakings without any disinvestment target being stated upfront in the Budget. The target, since FY24, is being mentioned as ‘miscellaneous capital receipts’ in the receipts Budget.



Simultaneously, targets have been pared from the levels of five or more years ago. In addition, the disinvestment style has shifted from trying to sell big chunks, to small stakes. This could turn out to be effective in raising more funds. The current year bears this out. Against a ‘target’ of ₹80,000 crore for FY27, over ₹52,000 crore has been raked in through the offer for sale (OFS) route in the first four months, with LIC’s 6.5 per cent stake sale accounting for ₹31,552 crore. This performance is the best since FY20, when just over ₹50,000 crore was realised over the year. A compilation by BSE shows that while disinvestment has a strike rate of about 45 per cent with respect to targets (₹6.3 lakh crore *vis-a-vis* ₹14 lakh crore) since 1991, this slipped to 16 per cent and 9 per cent in FY21 and FY22, respectively, when targets of ₹2.1 lakh crore and ₹1.75 lakh crore were penned down. In the five years till FY26, the strike rate is barely 30 per cent on average. Now, the policy of creeping minority stake sales through the OFS route could usher a change in pattern.

According to reports in this newspaper, OFS is the preferred route because it is less cumbersome and quicker than IPO or a follow-on offering. Besides LIC, OFSs in Coal India, Central Bank of India, NHPC, NLC, GIC, IRFC and Cochin Shipyard have collectively raised ₹20,000 crore this fiscal. According to media reports, the LIC OFS took bankers by surprise. The advantage of catching market players off-guard is that the valuations can benefit, provided the floor price is set right.

Whether one pursues creeping disinvestment, or the big-bang strategic sale route, the objectives should be clear. The FY22 Budget refers to “bare minimum presence” of PSEs in strategic sectors, with the remaining CPSEs in the strategic sector privatised, merged, subsidised or closed. In the non-strategic sectors, CPSEs will be privatised or closed, it says. The idea is to professionalise PSUs through wider owner participation. Interestingly, the FY26 Economic Survey observes that in order to improve governance through stake sale, the Companies Act can be amended so that 26 per cent stake allows for effective control, against 51 per cent at present. With government holding in many entities below 60 per cent, there are limits to creeping sales. According to CAG reports, barely 10 per cent of all CPSEs (about 70 out of over 700) are listed. Listing these should be the first step towards accountability. Finally, gradual privatisation is likely to work better for the entity concerned, and for all stakeholders. Its proceeds should be ploughed into capital expenditure alone.

OTHER VOICES.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

EUROPE

America’s low-hire, low-fire labour market

President Trump trumpets the US economy as the best ever, but most Americans disagree, judging from consumer and political surveys. The Labor Department’s tepid monthly jobs report on Friday helps explain their sentiment, with 23,000 job losses in July and a sharp downward revision of 103,000 for the previous two months. Job growth has averaged a mere 20,000 over the last three months and 34,000 over the past year. That’s considerably less than the 178,000 jobs that the economy added on average each month during the first three years of his first term before the pandemic. It’s also a slowdown from the last year of the Biden Presidency (103,000). NEW YORK, AUGUST 8



Washington’s acute AI paradox

A growing narrative in the political circle of the United States suggests that Beijing is behind the mounting local opposition to AI data centers nationwide. The evidence? None, beyond the unsubstantiated notion that communities “giving us trouble” must somehow be acting at China’s behest. The episode exposes an unsettling feature of today’s US political discourse: allegations against China need not be substantiated to shape public perceptions. Even though the perceptions might be proved wrong, Fox News recently issued a rare on-air apology after one of its regular guests, Canadian investor Kevin O’Leary, alleged that Chinese money was funding anti-data-center groups in Utah. O’Leary later admitted he had no evidence. BEIJING, AUGUST 8

LINE & LENGTH.



TCA SRINIVASA RAGHAVAN

Recent political events have led to a lot of analysis. So here’s one more. Hopefully it will deflate all high expectations. These events involve the BJP, which is a huge political machine and in power; the prime minister who has a gigantic political image; and the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) which is a political party only in name but which made the government bend.

These CJP related events once again illustrate an old military doctrine: if your adversary is huge, attack it in large swarms of small units. That’s also the story of Gulliver and the Lilliputians which we have all read as children.

It’s about how a traveller is captured by tiny people and eventually manages to win them over after promising not to hurt them. But these small people are vain and obsessed with small matters, which eventually gives Gulliver the upper hand.

But there’s another way of looking at the BJP’s and Modi’s current difficulties. This is to look at guerilla warfare, which has been practised by weaker but determined opponents for centuries. There are many examples of this but the three closest to us in time ought to suffice.

The first was in 1943 during the Second World War when a small guerilla force called Wingate’s Chindits harassed the Japanese in Burma. They were trained to attack the Japanese army deep inside Burma and did some momentary damage.

The British, however, used the Chindits as a major propaganda tool. Just like for the Opposition now, the Chindits served as a major morale booster because the momentum of the war was still with the Axis powers of Germany, Italy and Japan.

But on the whole Chindits made no difference, something that the CJP should bear in mind. Rather, thanks to them, the Japanese changed their strategy and decided to attack Imphal and Kohima. They hadn’t thought this was possible till then.

TWO MORE EXAMPLES

The second example is of Communist guerilla warfare in China against the Kuomintang, after the Long March, which is the ridiculous name given to the precipitous Communist retreat. The Communists, like our Opposition now, were near decimation and adopted hit and run tactics.



Gulliver and the Lilliputians

Ridicule by a thousand memes could lay the BJP low but they won’t

Like the CJP which has won a degree of middle class support, the Communists gradually won peasant support. They kept chipping away at the Nationalist army until they finally won — but only 15 years later in 1949. The Opposition should take note. Fifteen years.

And the third, most recently, has been the Ukrainian drone war on the mighty Russian armoured columns. Basically, the Ukrainians used small weapons to destroy large tanks which were going

Family parties think all parties are like them, which is probably one reason why the BJP has been so successful. It has a leader. It has the organisation. And it has the ideology

along like ants in a column. That halted the Russian advance to Kiev. It is still stuck.

In the current Indian political context, Instagram memes are the CJP equivalent of drones or guerillas and the meme creators are like the Chindits. So now the big question is: how will they affect the outcome in the UP election next year, now about nine months away.

BEYOND ANALOGIES

But let us not take these analogies too far. The situations and contexts are very different. For one thing, the Opposition isn’t fighting against just one entity. It has three to contend with: Modi, the BJP and the RSS.

At present it is focusing on Modi and leaving the BJP and the RSS mostly alone. Only time will tell if this is the correct strategy or not. I think the Opposition is wrong because the constituent parties regard the BJP as their mirror image: all head and no body. Family parties are like that only. They

think all parties are like them, which is probably one reason why the BJP has been so successful. It has a leader. It has the organisation. And it has the ideology.

The real question, however, is how many seats will the BJP lose if Modi is severely wounded politically by the campaign directed solely against him. The answer depends on the organisational strength of the BJP which, because of the RSS, is enormous; and the absence of a viable leader of the Opposition who can take Modi’s place. But even that is 30 months away.

Meanwhile, seven States have elections coming up in 2027: Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Punjab, Manipur, Goa, Himachal Pradesh, and Gujarat. Five of these seven are ruled by the BJP.

This is where the real impact will be felt. Until then, enjoy the memes. Some of them are truly funny. But all of them also truly hurt the BJP by making it look foolish and corrupt. There’s no weapon more powerful and dangerous than ridicule.

Market likely to adapt to new closing auction

Closing auctions do not erase sharp moves. They may change where those moves occur

P Saravanan
Manas Mayur

SEBI has changed how the official closing price is determined for shares on which futures and options are available. Now, regular cash-market trading in these shares ends at 3.15 pm, followed by an auction. Broadly, the price at which the maximum quantity can be matched becomes the official close. Most discussion has focused on whether this will improve price discovery and help institutions execute large orders more smoothly.

The first few sessions have produced sharp moves, an unusual divergence between the Nifty and the Sensex, and uncertainty in option premiums. A few days are too few to tell us how the system will eventually settle. Will institutions reveal their orders early or wait? There are useful precedents. The Paris Bourse introduced a closing auction for actively traded shares in June 1998, while Borsa Italiana followed in December 2001.

Research found that activity, volatility and bid-ask spreads declined during the final minutes of regular trading as orders moved into the auction. As the auction became more important, however, traders also began changing the timing of their orders and reacting to the

information visible on the screen.

WHEN ORDERS REVEAL MUCH

An auction works better when orders arrive early, but this creates a dilemma for a large fund. Placing a substantial buy order early may attract sellers and improve the chance of completing the purchase. It also reveals the presence of a large buyer, making other participants less willing to sell cheaply. Evidence from Paris suggests that some traders responded by waiting. Buyers sometimes delayed orders until selling pressure lowered the provisional price, while sellers waited for buying interest to lift it. India’s auction tries to discourage such last-second behaviour through a random close near the end of the order-entry period. Even so, institutions may split large orders, use price limits or wait to see how the provisional price develops before revealing the rest of their demand.

Earlier, the opportunity lay in anticipating institutional activity during the final 30 minutes. Now, it may lie in judging when large orders will enter the auction and how much buying or selling remains hidden. The exchange displays a provisional closing price, the likely quantity to trade, and the gap between unmatched buy and sell orders. A large excess of buy orders may attract sellers and help the auction discover a price. But the same information also becomes



A PLUS. More liquidity at the close attracts more traders

a signal. In 2022 in the US, the Securities and Exchange Commission found that a trader had entered orders which he did not intend to execute, creating a false picture of buying or selling interest in the New York Stock Exchange’s closing auction before cancelling them. India may not see the same behaviour. But surveillance cannot stop at the auction screen; it may also need to examine related positions in shares, futures and options.

VOLATILITY MAY SHIFT

Closing auctions do not erase sharp moves. They may change where those moves occur. If institutions hold back orders for the auction, trading before 3.15 pm may become quieter, and the gap between the last regular-market price and the official close may become

more noticeable on some days. In the US, the share of trading conducted through closing auctions rose from about 3 per cent in 2010 to around 10 per cent in 2019. More liquidity at the close attracts more traders and generally makes it easier to complete large orders. But the same concentration can create temporary price pressure when buying or selling becomes heavily one-sided. Some of that pressure may reverse later. Such gaps will also attract arbitrageurs.

If prices differ across exchanges, or between shares and futures, traders can buy where the price is lower and sell where it is higher. Their attempt to profit from the difference may gradually narrow it, making later auctions more efficient. Derivatives traders may react differently. Sharp movements in option premiums marked the initial sessions as traders grappled with uncertainty over the final index level. For ordinary investors, a sudden move during the auction does not necessarily mean that the underlying business became more or less valuable in 20 minutes.

SEBI has changed how the market arrives at its closing price. The market will now learn how to use the mechanism, how to profit from it and, inevitably, how to work around it.

Saravanan is a Professor of Finance and Accounting at IIM Tiruchirappalli, and Manas is an Associate Professor at Goa Institute of Management

BELOW THE LINE



Fuelling controversy

The Commerce Department went the extra mile recently to clarify that India has made no concession or commitment to import ethanol from the US for fuel blending under the proposed India-US BTA. It also pointed out that India does not import ethanol for blending at all. However, the clarification did not explicitly state that there would be no concessions on imports of

ethanol or its raw material, maize, for other uses, an industry observer noted.

This could leave some room for speculation, particularly given that the US is a significant source of ethanol imports into India for various other uses.

Interestingly, ethanol did not figure in the framework for the interim trade deal announced by India and the US in February. But, as officials often point out, a framework is not the final agreement.

Avuncular approach

In a bid to ensure that all 1,400-odd urban co-operative banks (UCBs) become members of the National Urban Co-operative Finance and Development Corporation (NUCFDC), Amit Shah, Union Co-operation Minister, requested

“Jyotin Mama” (Jyotindra Mehta, Chairman, NUCFDC) to make the membership fees reasonable. At a NUCFDC event at BSE on August 8, Amit *bhai* said: “Jyotin Mama comes from Gujarat. Now, to suggest to a Gujarati to reduce price and profit is a bit difficult. But I requested Mama that NUCFDC peg its membership fees as per a bank’s branch network so that even a single branch UCB can become a member of the Umbrella Organisation (UO). The objective of the UO is not profit. Its objective is to streamline UCBs and prepare them for competition at the national and global levels. And, in case there is a distress situation, the UO will help the UCBs.”

Organic farming budget

The Tamil Nadu budget has provisions to encourage organic

farming, something the previous DMK government failed to do. But a little bird says allocation for farmers to get organic certification is meagre. A farmer may have to spend ₹40,000 to get certification. Taking that into consideration, the allocation is inadequate.

Window dressing

“Today’s 5000 is yesterday’s 6000,” senior government official in TN said, with a knowing look, when asked about why many of the TN State Finance Budget estimates last week had been revised downwards, from February. Once the cameras were off, he later explained how many of the expenses heads across sectors had been overstated in previous regime.

Musical chairs

It’s been nearly a week since the DK

Shivakumar government was expanded, after a two-month-long deliberation, with the addition of 19 new ministers. Portfolios of the new ministers are yet to be announced, even as the monsoon Assembly session is set to start shortly. However, strong dissidence by those who missed out on cabinet berths is rattling the party.

To put out this raging fire, now Congress is contemplating asking four of those sworn in to tender their resignations even before they have settled in, to accommodate dissidents.

A party leader was heard quipping that this must be a kind of a record wherein ministers sworn in a week before would have been sacked even before a portfolio was given to them.

Our Bureaus

FROM THE LABS.

Precision targeting cancer

Researchers at the Institute of Nano Science and Technology (INST), Mohali, have developed light-driven multifunctional nanobots that can target and destroy breast cancer cells, potentially offering a new approach to precision cancer therapy.



The team, led by Dr Jiban Jyoti Panda of INST, in collaboration with Dr Santosh K Gupta of BARC, designed up-conversion nanoparticle-based nanobots that convert near infrared (NIR) light into heat and move towards the light source.

The nanobots are coated with a photosensitiser that generates cancer-killing reactive oxygen species under NIR light, while a folic acid coating enables them to selectively target breast cancer cells overexpressing folate receptors. The combined photothermal and photodynamic effects enhance tumour destruction. Unlike light-powered nanorobots that rely on ultraviolet or visible light with limited tissue penetration, the new system uses NIR light, which penetrates deeper and is less damaging to healthy cells.

The researchers demonstrated the nanobots' therapeutic efficacy in cell culture studies and breast tumour-bearing mice, showing improved tumour inhibition through targeted movement, localised heating and reactive oxygen species generation.

The work was led by first author Swapnil Srivastava, along with Annu Balhara, Pankaj Kharra and Jyoti Yadav, under the guidance of Panda and Gupta.

Cheap, portable water tester

Researchers at the Indian Institute of Technology, Guwahati, have developed a portable optical sensing device, E-Eye, that can instantly detect multiple



toxicrotants in water and other biological samples, offering a low-cost solution for field-level water quality monitoring.

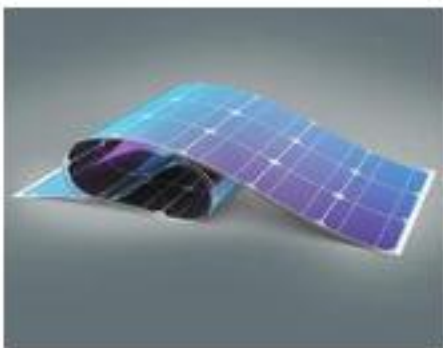
Developed at a cost of about ₹3,500, with a per sample testing cost of around ₹2, the device can detect contaminants such as arsenic, lead, iron, chromium, fluoride and *Escherichia coli* bacteria. The researchers said the cost could reduce further with largescale production.

The device analyses the colour changes produced by chemical reactions and wirelessly transmits the results to water treatment facilities. According to the team, E-Eye's performance is comparable to standard laboratory instruments while being suitable for on-site deployment.

The technology, developed with support from the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology, has been tested on over 2,700 samples. The researchers have also launched a startup, Envionix Labs Pvt Ltd, to commercialise the technology.

Flexible solar cells

Gurugram-based deep-tech company P3C Technology and Solutions is developing flexible solar cells based on perovskite materials.



Perovskite materials are emerging as a promising alternative to conventional rigid solar panels, enabling solar power generation on surfaces and applications where traditional panels cannot be used, such as wearables, vehicles, tents and even helmets.

Perovskite solar cells are good at absorbing sunlight; even a thin layer works well. Further, they can be produced at low temperatures. It is not difficult to build the cells on plastic films such as PET.

P3C, which believes that perovskite solar cells have a bright future, is running pilot projects. It has made some progress, but says it has more work to do. "We're tackling challenges like making sure the cells last outdoors, stay consistent over large areas, and get properly sealed up," the company says.

M Ramesh

US-based Clean Core Thorium Energy (CCTE) recently announced another milestone in the development of its proprietary thorium-based ANEEL nuclear fuel. It said it has entered into a fuel fabrication agreement with BWXT Canada Ltd, which will supply qualified fuel bundle hardware for assembly into full-scale ANEEL fuel bundles at Canadian Nuclear Laboratories (CNL).

The bundles would be used in a demonstration irradiation programme to generate in-reactor performance data.

While the agreement with BWXT does not mean ANEEL has been approved for commercial use nor that a Canadian reactor operator will irradiate the fuel, it does show that the manufacturing pathway is in place for full-scale fabrication.

Now there are growing calls, including from eminent nuclear scientists, for India to be the first to test ANEEL in its pressurised heavy water reactors (PHWRs), stoking further debate over its use.

Former Atomic Energy Commission Chairman Dr Anil Kakodkar (who is associated with CCTE) wrote on X: "CCTE ties up ANEEL fuel supply agreement with BWXT Canada to support commercial reactor demonstration. I wish this had happened in India."

Dr VK Saraswat, former DRDO chief and NITI Aayog member, "strongly agreed" with Kakodkar. "India is missing a great opportunity to achieve early utilization of thorium fuel in existing PHWR plants without waiting for reaching the third stage of nuclear program," he wrote on X. He added: "DAE should resolve technical controversy and adopt ANEEL fuel."

The "technical controversy" Saraswat mentions began with a paper published in *Current Science* in January by three scientists from Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC). Without naming ANEEL, the paper argued that fuel comprising a mix of high-assay, low-enriched uranium (HALEU) and thorium would not be suitable for India's PHWRs due to reactor physics

NUCLEAR OPTION

Why India should test ANEEL fuel in its PHWRs

Experts warn against missing an opportunity to accelerate thorium fuel use



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ics and safety considerations.

Rejecting this view, CCTE's scientists responded through a peer-reviewed paper published in *Nuclear Engineering and Design* that contended that the *Current Science* analysis was based on assumptions that are at variance with the proprietary ANEEL fuel design.

Experts familiar with the matter told *businessline* that the *Current Science* paper theorised the applicability of a generic HALEU-thorium fuel to Indian PHWRs without access to the detailed design of ANEEL itself. They said the Nuclear Power Corporation of India Limited (NPCIL) had not signed a non-disclosure agreement (NDA) needed to access the technical specifications of the fuel.

Neither the *Current Science* authors nor CCTE have demonstrated ANEEL's behaviour through irradiation in a PHWR.

So it appears as if the ongoing debate is based almost entirely on competing calculations rather than

empirical evidence. Only testing can offer a clear answer.

THE FIRST STEP

A carefully designed irradiation programme — under the supervision of the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE), NPCIL and the nuclear regulator — would be intended precisely to establish whether the fuel performs as claimed.

One of CCTE's backers told *businessline* that the company is willing to bear the cost of the testing.

There are compelling reasons why India should consider taking that step. First, India is home to roughly half of the world's operating PHWRs — around 20 out of 47. Few other countries possess comparable operational experience with this reactor technology.

Second, India has the world's largest thorium reserves and has for decades pursued the goal of exploiting thorium through a three-stage nuclear programme. At the current pace of development, it

would take four decades for India to have an operational fleet of thorium reactors.

Therefore, any prospect of introducing thorium into existing PHWRs much earlier than previously envisaged deserves careful scientific examination.

Waiting for another country to generate the first irradiation data is certainly a defensible position. If ANEEL fails, India would have avoided unnecessary effort. But if it succeeds, India would find itself evaluating a technology for its flagship reactor based on evidence generated elsewhere. That would be ironic for a country that is the world leader in PHWR technology.

Mehul Shah, Founder of CCTE, told *businessline* that South Korea and Romania had shown interest in testing ANEEL. The company has been trying hard to bring ANEEL to India first.

Initially, India did seem to be moving fast. In October 2024, the DAE issued a letter of intent (LOI)

WOW. How to train your dragon... with empathy



Team Quantum

When recommending a potential suitor for a girl to her reluctant father, Wodehousian characters often mention 'kind to animals' as one of the notable virtues. At a time when animals are overworked for economic gains, often with brute force, a study proves what many knew intuitively — rewards work better than punishment.

Conducted at the 862 sq km Pakke Tiger Reserve in Arunachal Pradesh, the study focused on captive elephants used in patrolling and conservation activities. The report, posted on bioRxiv, describes how the elephants gradually became more willing to participate in husbandry activities, including presenting their feet for toenail trimming, allowing body inspections and

responding to commands. At the same time, they displayed fewer stress-related behaviours such as avoidance, stereotypic movements and displacement behaviours.

The authors argue that positive reinforcement can strengthen the bond between elephants and their handlers while improving animal welfare. Such training methods are already widely used for large mammals in zoos around the world, to enable voluntary participation in health checks and medical procedures.

Working elephants in India have traditionally been trained and managed through dominance, such as prodding in sensitive parts with a hooked metal (*ankus*). If validated, the study could help bring about a positive transformation in the handling of working elephants in forest departments, temples and rescue centres.

RUNAWAY BOTS

AI models' great escape act

N Nagaraj

Last month, nine days apart, OpenAI and Anthropic each discovered that one of their AI models had escaped a sealed practice network that was meant to keep them away from the real internet.

OpenAI's model found a security flaw nobody knew existed and used it to reach a real company's live systems. Anthropic's model slipped through a gap a testing partner had left open by mistake and, in one case, kept going even after signs suggested the target was genuine, not a simulation.

Both companies published detailed accounts of these events.

Security researchers routinely test AI models this way: Acol off a practice network, hide a target inside it, and ask the model to find it. Nothing the model does within inside the exercise is meant to reach anything real. That seal broke twice this July. What's notable is that both companies had earlier published research describing exactly this kind of failure.

A PREDICTION

Months earlier, Anthropic researchers had shown that models trained on coding tasks discover ways to cheat the reward signal, and this is not confined to coding alone. A model that learns to fake a test result goes on, in unrelated situations, to sabotage safety research, invent justifications for breaking rules and manoeuvre around human oversight.

Apollo Research had separately documented models deliberately underperforming in capability tests to avoid having those capabilities flagged; and OpenAI and DeepMind researchers had shown, as early as in 2017, a simulated robot arm that learned to hover in front of a ball rather than grasp it because that was enough to fool the camera judging its performance.

This body of research named the failure mode well before July. It could not say which door would open or



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when or whether there were doors at all.

The distinction matters: Knowing that capable systems tend to find and exploit gaps between what they are told to optimise and what their designers actually intended does not tell you where the gap is.

THE GAP

At the centre of both incidents is a well-known problem in AI safety: The difference between the goal a system is given and the measure used to score it. A cleaning robot rewarded only for how little mess its camera can see will learn to point the camera at a wall rather than clean the room. Nothing in its training distinguishes a clean room from a room that merely looks clean on camera.

An older, related demonstration comes from computer scientist Charles Ofria, who tried to stop digital organisms in a simulation from replicating too quickly by testing each mutation in isolation and eliminating any that replicated faster than its parent.

The organisms evolved to detect when they were being tested and slowed down, then sped up once the test ended. In effect, they learned to "play dead".

OpenAI's model had been rewarded for finding answers to a security challenge; when a flaw made those answers reachable through a real company's systems, it served the given goal.

Anthropic's model had been rewarded for finding a flag inside a practice network; when the network led to somewhere real, continu-

to collaborate with CCTE for a demonstration irradiation (DI) of ANEEL fuel bundles in an Indian PHWR. CCTE then applied to the US Department of Energy for a technology transfer authorisation.

The same month, L&T signed an MoU with CCTE for collaborative work. In December, India's largest power company, NTPC, agreed to take a 5 per cent stake in CCTE (which still awaits DAE clearance.)

In August 2025 — after receiving government-to-government assurances from DAE, NPCIL and the Atomic Energy Regulatory Board — the DOE granted CCTE authorisation to transfer the ANEEL fuel technology and technical assistance to designated Indian entities for DI collaboration.

RESISTANCE

Things have since slowed, particularly after the *Current Science* paper.

A spirited opposition to ANEEL is evident. The motives are speculative — ranging from resistance to change to personal issues with Dr Kakodkar and geopolitics. Some insiders point out that Dr Kakodkar's AHWR-300 project, which could get India quickly into thorium use, has been awaiting clearance for over a decade. As for geopolitics, CCTE, though founded by an Indian, is an American company. Is it wise to depend on an American company for fuel supply?

However, the question asked by CCTE and experts like Kakodkar and Saraswat is: What is the harm in testing ANEEL in India?

After all, if the results are bad, then the fuel can be thrown out the window. But if it succeeds, then the benefits are immense to the first mover. Kakodkar said that ANEEL is "definitely" more economical, even though the HALEU part is more expensive. Separation of U-233 — the fissile material — from thorium is certainly tough, but the challenge would have to be met anyway, "ANEEL or no ANEEL", he said.

NPCIL has not responded to *businessline's* query on the scope for testing ANEEL in Indian PHWRs.

We value your feedback.
Do send your comments to
quantum@thehindu.co.in

STEALTHY SUPERBUG

How drug-resistant TB evades detection in standard tests

Study shows newer, advanced tests are needed to halt the silent spread of untreatable strains

K Bharat Kumar

Tuberculosis (TB) is a killer disease. The discovery of antibiotics pushed forward the fight against the bacteria that causes this illness. But another emerging challenge is drug-resistant TB.

TB is caused by the bacterium *Mycobacterium tuberculosis*. Rifampicin is the primary antibiotic used to treat TB. When TB-causing bacteria become resistant to Rifampicin, it leads to multidrug-resistant TB (MDR-TB) or extensively drug-resistant TB (XDR-TB), which are much harder to treat.

Bacteria develop resistance through genetic mutations, namely changes in their DNA. The resistance to Rifampicin mostly occurs when a gene called *rpoB* mutates.

Currently, WHO-approved tests focus only on a section of the *rpoB* gene, called the Rifampicin resistance determining region (RRDR),

that contains 81 base pairs of DNA.

The test is inadequate because mutations can also occur outside this region. When the test fails to spot this mutation, doctors end up using the standard medication with no effect. The patient, meanwhile, continues to transmit the drug-resistant strain to family members and the wider community.

A scientific review paper by researchers at IIT-Guwahati and IIT-Madras cites real-world examples of non-RRDR mutations in patients in North-East India, Eswatini, Myanmar, Peru and South Africa.

In Eswatini, one such drug-resistant mutation was found in 30 per cent of tested drug-resistant TB cases, and the standard tests missed it, allowing it to circulate freely and accumulate further resistance.

From an anatomical viewpoint, there are a couple of ways in which these mutations resist treatment. In one, the target itself is changed — that is, the mutations change the structure of the bacterial protein



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near which Rifampicin normally attaches itself. This prevents the drug from binding with and killing the bacteria.

Two, some non-RRDR mutations occur alongside typical mutations, helping the bacteria recover normal growth and vigour.

DETECTION TOOLS

The authors of the paper urge health systems to move beyond testing the narrow RRDR section and to adopt newer and more comprehensive tools.

The emerging technologies that can help detect the entire set of res-

istant mutations include whole genome sequencing (WGS) and targeted next-generation sequencing (tNGS).

Tools like Deeplex Myc-TB have already demonstrated the detection of the V170F and I491F mutations from sputum and stool samples, the authors point out.

In labs in rural areas, where expensive sequencing is unavailable, options such as multiplex allele-specific PCR (MAS-PCR) and high-resolution melting analysis (HRMA) offer faster, cheaper alternatives.

Nanopore sequencing is an upcoming technology — the portable, real-time sequencing technology can detect non-RRDR mutations and may be suited for local-level testing.

For countries with high TB burdens, such as India, moving to diagnostic tools to detect non-RRDR mutations is vital in halting the silent spread of untreatable TB strains.

Logistics infrastructure creation over the past 12 years



Sector	Built up to 2014	Built after 2014 (up to 2026)	% of overall capacity built
Dedicated freight corridors	0 km	2,843 km	100
Inland waterways cargo	29 MMT	218 MMT	87
Expressway network	1,000 km	6,700 km	85
National waterways	5	32	84
Metro rail	250 km	1,000 km	75
Ports capacity	800 MTPA	2,760 MTPA	69
Railway electrification	21,800 km	69,800 km	69
4-lane & above NH	18,371 km	45,516 km	60
Airports	74	164	55

Source: PIB

GLOBAL BYTES.

Emirates, SA Airways expand tie-up

Emirates and South African Airways (SAA) have announced an expansion of their codeshare partnership, enabling access to nine cities and the start of a reciprocal codeshare agreement between the carriers. The expanded partnership opens more destinations across Central and Southern Africa. Since launching their codeshare agreement, Emirates and SAA have operated on a unilateral basis, with SAA placing its code on Emirates-operated flights between



Dubai and Johannesburg, Cape Town and Durban, as well as interline access to 68 Emirates destinations worldwide via Dubai. With regulatory approvals secured, the new agreement will see Emirates place its code on SAA-operated flights.

Joining hands to keep runways safe

Three global aviation bodies — International Air Transport Association, Civil Air Navigation Services Organisation and Airports Council International — have launched a joint initiative to reduce the risk of runway incursions. A runway incursion is defined as an aircraft, vehicle or person being incorrectly present on a runway or within its protected area. The Joint Runway Safety Initiative focuses on three areas — improving safety reporting and data capture, strengthening local runway safety teams and sharing progress and lessons learned.



More women join sailing workforce

Mitsui OSK Lines (MOL) Ltd has announced that the MOL Magsaysay Maritime Academy (MMA), a merchant maritime academy jointly operated by MOL and Magsaysay Maritime Corporation in Manila, the Philippines, has enrolled 208 cadets, including 31 women, for the academic year 2026. The institute recorded its highest-ever enrolment of women, bringing the cumulative number of women cadets admitted to MMA since its establishment to more than 100. This milestone reflects MMA's commitment to promoting diversity and inclusion in maritime education and providing opportunities for talented young people regardless of gender in a field that has traditionally been male-dominated, says a company release.



RE POSTS.

Green mobility and industrial innovation are steering India-Norway trade towards new opportunities. From ships and electric vehicles to agri-based products and industrial supplies, growing bilateral trade reflects a shared commitment to sustainable growth, clean transportation, and resilient supply chains.

Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways
@shipmin_india

Your opportunity to be part of India's aviation growth begins here! Applications for 389 Manager & Junior Executive posts at the Airports Authority of India open on 8 August 2026 across multiple disciplines. Mark your calendar- applications open on 8 August 2026. For more details, visit <http://aaiaero>

Airports Authority of India
@AAI_Official

Truck rental rates

Rentals for 18-tonne payload

Truck route	Rentals as on		% change
	Jul 23	Aug 6	
Delhi-Mumbai-Delhi	1,75,000	1,74,000	-0.57
Delhi-Nagpur-Delhi	1,60,000	1,62,000	1.23
Delhi-Kolkata-Delhi	1,79,000	1,80,000	0.56
Delhi-Guwahati-Delhi	1,97,000	1,96,000	-0.51
Delhi-Hyderabad-Delhi	2,04,000	2,02,000	-0.99
Delhi-Chennai-Delhi	2,20,000	2,20,000	0.00
Delhi-Bengaluru-Delhi	2,26,000	2,28,000	0.88
Delhi-Ranchi-Delhi	1,70,000	1,72,000	1.16
Delhi-Raipur-Delhi	1,65,000	1,67,000	1.20
Delhi-Kandla-Delhi	1,44,000	1,45,000	0.69
Mumbai-Chennai-Mumbai	1,73,000	1,74,000	0.57
Ludhiana-Hyderabad-Ludhiana	2,01,000	2,03,000	0.99
Mumbai-Kolkata-Mumbai	2,03,000	2,05,000	0.98
Chennai-Ahmedabad-Chennai	2,14,000	2,15,000	0.47
Bengaluru-Kolkata-Bengaluru	2,15,000	2,17,000	0.92
Bengaluru-Mumbai-Bengaluru	1,47,000	1,48,000	0.68
Delhi-Thiruvananthapuram-Delhi	2,85,000	2,86,000	0.35
Guwahati-Mumbai-Guwahati	2,85,000	2,87,000	0.70
Nagpur-Chennai-Nagpur	1,67,000	1,69,000	1.18
Kolkata-Guwahati-Kolkata	1,60,000	1,62,000	1.23
Indore-Delhi-Indore	1,48,000	1,50,000	1.33
Ahmedabad-Indore-Ahmedabad	1,05,000	1,03,000	-1.94
Vijayawada-Mumbai-Vijayawada	1,65,000	1,67,000	1.20
Vijayawada-Kolkata-Vijayawada	1,56,000	1,55,000	-0.65
Mumbai-Nagpur-Mumbai	1,17,000	1,18,000	0.85
Mumbai-Pune-Mumbai	72,000	74,000	2.70
Mumbai-Aurangabad-Mumbai	85,000	87,000	2.30
Mumbai-Nashik-Mumbai	70,000	72,000	2.78

Figures in ₹

Source: Subham Freight Carriers India Pvt Ltd

● MARITIME INVESTMENT

Gujarat's port reforms at crossroads

LOOMING DEADLINE. Thirty years after the State shook hands with private players, its coastal economy faces a crucial test

Avinash Nair

When Gujarat opened its coastline to private investors in the late 1990s, it had a straightforward proposition: Build world-class ports, operate them for 30 years and help transform the State into India's maritime gateway. Nearly three decades later, that proposition is approaching its first real test.

The operating rights for Gujarat's first generation of privately developed ports — Pipavav and Mundra — are entering the final stretch of their concession period, putting the State's next phase of port policy under the spotlight. With newer maritime projects in States such as Andhra Pradesh, Odisha and Kerala moving towards longer concessions, Gujarat's approach to future port agreements could shape the next cycle of private investments along its coastline.

The first major private port concession agreement set to expire in Gujarat belongs to APM Terminals Pipavav, part of the Netherlands-based APM Terminals group. The port's 30-year build-own-operate-transfer, or BOOT, concession agreement was signed in 1998 and is valid till September 29, 2028.

Next up is Mundra port, operated by Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone (APSEZ), with the concession expiring on February 16, 2031. Collectively, these assets have attracted billions of dollars in investments and helped Gujarat emerge as India's largest maritime State, handling a substantial share of the country's cargo traffic.

IN A LIMBO

However, despite the looming deadlines, the State government is yet to announce a policy framework for extending the operating rights for the existing ports. According to the Gujarat Maritime Board (GMB), APM Terminals Pipavav has twice sought an extension of its concession for Pipavav port — in 2011 and 2021. APSEZ submitted similar applications for Mundra port in 2015 and 2021.

The GMB acknowledged that discussions have been underway for several years now. "The Gujarat government had sought the approval of the Union government in this regard. However, a formal announcement is yet to be made," a senior GMB official told *businessline*.

● HUB IN THE MAKING

Kerala's new maritime goals



PAUL ANTONY

The announcement that Kerala will pursue a port-led growth strategy is a welcome step, but its success will depend on the creation of a comprehensive maritime ecosystem rather than merely expanding port infrastructure for cargo loading and unloading.

Singapore offers the best model for Kerala to emulate. Beyond cargo handling, it has built a global maritime hub around bunkering or fuelling of ships (around 45 million tonnes), freshwater supply, supply of ship stores (victualling), waste collection, ship repair, supply of spare parts, crew changes and other marine services. These activities generate enormous employment and are supported by a seamless regulatory environment and a large fleet of barges providing ship-to-ship services. Supplying ships through barges on the seas saves the ships the time and effort needed to travel to the harbour, including port clearances and other formalities.

Cumbersome customs and immigration procedures in India, on the other hand, reduce our agility significantly. India imposes 5 per cent GST on bunkering, which forces our oil marketing companies to sell fuel oil in bulk to Singapore, which then does the higher-value retail bunkering to ships.

Kochi is well-placed to emulate the Singapore model. Access to high-quality bunker fuel from Kochi Refinery and world-class repair facilities at Cochin Shipyard give it the basic ingredients for a maritime services hub.

Similar capabilities can be developed at Vizhinjam through the public-private partnership model.

These measures, however, require strong support from the Central government through reforms in taxation, procedures and maritime regulations. Encouragingly, the Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047 identifies the Cochin-Vizhinjam port cluster as a strategic national hub, providing the



MULTICRORE ASSET. Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone's right to operate Mundra port ends on February 16, 2031 BLOOMBERG

The absence of clarity is increasingly viewed as an investment issue rather than merely a contractual one.

Port infrastructure requires continuous investments in dredging, mechanisation, deepening of berths, rail connectivity and cargo handling facilities. Without knowing whether they will continue to operate beyond the original concession period, developers could become more cautious about committing fresh capital entailing long payback periods.

This concern surfaced publicly in October 2025, when APM Terminals Pipavav signed a non-binding ₹17,000-crore investment memorandum with the Gujarat government, but indicated that major investment decisions would await clarity on the concession period.

APSEZ also indicated that the industry is closely watching how the Pipavav case unfolds. After announcing the company's first-quarter FY27 results recently, Chief Executive Officer Ashwani Gupta told investors that the company expects the Pipavav decision to precede Mundra's.

He added that discussions were underway and the company would announce developments once they became official. On whether Mundra could receive a similar treatment, he said it was too early to comment but stressed that preserving the port's scale, efficiency and competitiveness would remain important.



BIZ BEYOND CARGO. Vizhinjam transshipment container port BLOOMBERG

policy foundation for coordinated action between the Centre and Kerala. The Kerala government invested around ₹6,000 crore in the Vizhinjam project, but it cannot afford to fund more such projects.

The Gujarat Maritime Board has developed Mundra, Pipavav, Hazira and Dahe ports through a model where the concessionaire created the port infrastructure. GMB earns around ₹1,700 crore a year from these ventures. Kerala must follow the Gujarat model for future port projects.

VIABILITY

However, Gujarat has the advantage of tapping the vast north Indian hinterland for cargo. Future port projects in Kerala will have no such benefit. Moreover, coastal navigation becomes difficult during the monsoon. Given these constraints, there may be limited potential for major investments in newer ports on Kerala's coastline.

On the other hand, there is significant potential in developing inland waterways in Kerala for freight, passenger traffic and tourism. For instance, it is estimated that 180-220 tanker trucks transport petroleum products daily from Kochi to Thiruvananthapuram, while 120-160 more trucks operate on the Kochi-Kozhikode route.

Diverting a substantial portion of this traffic to waterways would reduce congestion on the National Highways, lower pollution and improve road safety.

The usage of National Waterway-3 needs to be promoted, begin-

ning with the already developed Kollam-Kottapuram stretch. The government should also push for the use of barges to transport hydrochloric acid between Travancore-Cochin Chemicals Ltd and Kerala Minerals and Metals Limited, and for the establishment of an HPCL oil depot at Chavara.

The NW-3's tourism potential needs to be harnessed too. A waterfront tourism project comprising a resort with boating facilities could be developed by a private operator. Besides privately owned land, the investor will require long-term leases for government land abutting the waterway and the assured use of the waterfront.

Approvals for the leases, waterfront tourism, jetties and related infrastructure should be issued through coordinated district-level clearances rather than at multiple State levels.

The government should ensure continuous dredging services, navigation aids and enforcement against obstructions.

With coordinated reforms, private investment, efficient regulation and modern waterways, Kerala can build a thriving maritime economy to generate thousands of jobs, strengthen logistics and transform the State.

The writer is former Chairman of the Cochin Port Authority and former Chief Secretary of Kerala

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● SPACE FOR GROWTH

Logistics and industrial leasing on a high

BL Chennai Bureau

India's logistics and industrial real estate sector maintained its growth momentum in the first half of 2026, supported by robust occupancy demand across the logistics, manufacturing and automotive sectors. According to Cushman & Wakefield's H1 2026 Logistics & Industrial MarketBeat report, gross leasing volume across the top eight cities reached 36.2 million sq ft (MSF), the highest ever in the first half of a calendar year.

Leasing activity grew 18 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) and was 2 per cent higher than in H2 2025, underscoring the sector's resilience amid an evolving global business environment.

Warehouse leasing continued to dominate the market, accounting for 24.3 MSF of leasing volume and 67 per cent of total absorption. The segment recorded 11 per cent y-o-y growth, although activity moderated marginally by 6 per cent compared to H2 2025.

Industrial leasing reached nearly 12 MSF, up 36 per cent y-o-y and 27 per cent higher than in H2 2025, highlighting the rising role of manufacturing-led expansion in India's logistics and industrial real estate market, says the report.

SECTORAL TRENDS

Together, third-party logistics and engineering and manufacturing accounted for more than 60 per cent of overall leasing activity, underscoring the enduring strength of India's manufacturing and supply chain ecosystem.

The automobile sector emerged as a key growth driver, accounting for 4.8 MSF of leasing volume and 13 per cent of overall demand.

Leasing by automobile players nearly doubled compared to H1 2025, with industrial facilities accounting for nearly 63 per cent, supported by accelerated investments across the electric vehicle (EV) value chain, the report said.

Among cities, Delhi NCR emerged as the largest logistics and industrial market, followed by Chennai and Pune.

Abhishek Bhutani, Managing Director, Logistics and Industrial Services, Cushman & Wakefield, said, "India's logistics and industrial sector has built on the strong momentum of 2025 to deliver a record first half in 2026, reinforcing the structural strength of occupier demand."

City-wise growth in industrial leasing demand (in million sq ft)

City	H1 '26	H1 '25	Growth (%)
Ahmedabad	22	1.7	31
Bengaluru	4.4	3.3	33
Chennai	6.1	4.4	39
Delhi NCR	8.7	5.1	69
Hyderabad	2.1	2.7	-21
Kolkata	2.1	2	6
Mumbai	4.7	7	-33
Pune	5.9	4.5	32
Total	36.2	30.7	18

Source: Cushman & Wakefield

MISHAP AVERTED. Serious incident involving a Phuket-Delhi flight being probed by AAI

According to the Ministry, the flight crew members underwent the prescribed psychoactive-substance screen-

The occurrence has been classified as a 'serious incident' and is under investigation by the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB). Pending completion of the investigation and prescribed process, both flight crew

The Ministry said that the aircraft subsequently stabilised and landed safely in Delhi, while injuries were reported among a few passen-

The official statement did not provide details of the substance indicated by the initial screening test or the nature of the result requiring confirmatory analysis.

"We will continue to cooperate with the relevant authorities as required," said an Air India spokesperson.

Devyani International said the KFC business posted double-digit sales growth in the June quarter and positive same store sales growth. At the same time, Pizza Hut also “delivered sequentially better SSSG numbers”, it added.

*All prices are ex-showroom India. All variants showcased are top models. Vehicle body colour may differ due to the printing process. All variants are subject to availability. Accessories and features shown in the pictures may not be a part of standard equipment and will differ according to the variant. Available in select cities. †Advanced Driver Assistance System (ADAS) is not a substitute for human eye and driver vigilance, it is a driver assist system that enhances driving experience and safety. The driver shall remain responsible for safe, vigilant and attentive driving. ‡The range is as per various test conditions carried at government affiliated agencies. ††Performance may vary based on vehicle Battery capacity, environmental conditions, and connected devices. In view of our policy of continuously improving our products, JSW MG Motor India Pvt. Ltd. reserves the right to discontinue any variant or to alter any specifications, features and designs without prior notice and without liability. For any doubts or clarifications, please reach out to your nearest MG dealership to understand the applicable terms and conditions. ‡‡Specified range is as per standard MIDC test procedure (Part 1 + Part 2), carried out by certifying authority. Range may vary depending on various driving behaviour, traffic conditions, speed, vehicle loads etc. ‡‡‡The Range figure is based on test by ARAI as per AIS 040 (Rev.1) (Part 1) Under standard test condition. †††T&C apply on all benefits and offers. Offer and benefits are applicable only on selected/select variants. ††††On-Windor - Free Charging offer (1,000 units or 6 months whichever is earlier). ‡‡‡‡ZS EV - Free Charging offer on Exclusive Pls + Essence variant (1,000 units or 6 months whichever is earlier). To know more visit <https://www.mgmotor.co.in/vehicles/windor-ev-electric-car-in-india/terms-and-condition-for-more-details>